

Cause Track Analysis - Food Wastage



SUSTAINABILITY DIARY FOR MNA1099

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ABOUT

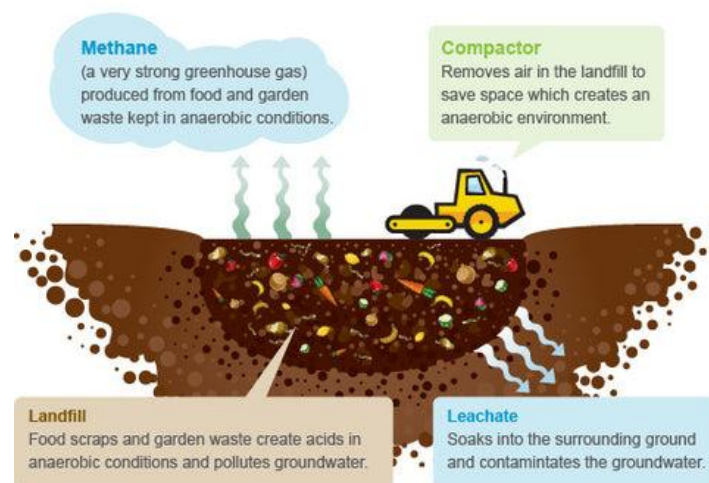
Every shift ends the same way, with bin bags full of perfectly edible food, and no say in what happens to it. This diary follows my former deli experience from frustrations to a structured analysis, tracing how kitchen food waste in Ireland is not a matter of carelessness but of organisational culture, weak policy and ignored voices. Drawing on personal experience, real data and conversations with those affected, I navigate a system that protects inefficiency and punishes good intentions. This is a story about who holds the power to change things, and why they haven't.

Foundations Pack

Introduction

Food wastage is a significant and often overlooked sustainability issue in Ireland and the rest of the world. In 2023, Ireland produced 835,000 tonnes of food waste, which is equivalent to 162kg per person (EPA, 2025). This issue spans the entirety of the food supply chain, where farmers discard imperfect produce, kitchens over prepare food goods and consumers order and purchase more than they need.

Beyond the statistics, there is a serious ethical concerns present. This is one where perfectly edible food is just disposed of whilst there are many adults and children alike facing food insecurity. We also can see environmental implications to food wastage, where waste decomposition leads to more methane emissions (Climate Change Advisory Council, 2024).



The primary reason I chose this as my cause track is because I really enjoy cooking and I always try to have the least amount of food wastage as possible. Before starting this track, I assumed that most food waste was from commercial operations through my first-hand experience with food wastage in my past job as a deli assistant. When I

worked there, we would fill multiple bin bags full of food waste every single day, and we were not allowed to give these “waste” food items away to those who would consume it. This issue concerns me because I control my food waste and still contribute a lot, so I can’t imagine the levels of food wastage that some individuals and businesses have.

Mapping the Causal Landscape

Food waste tends to be framed in public discourse as mainly a consumer issue. People often hear about households wasting food through promotions like buy one get one free deals or confusion over use by dates. Media and campaigns focus on individual habits and portion awareness. Businesses receive less attention while government approaches remain mostly voluntary through roadmaps rather than strict rules.

My own exposure came from working as a deli assistant. Each day we filled multiple bin bags with sandwiches salads and prepared foods that could have been eaten.

Company rules prevented us from donating any of it. This experience showed me operational waste that stays hidden from customers unlike the over ordering they notice at their tables.

EPA data paints a broader picture across the supply chain. Ireland generated 835,000 tonnes of food waste in 2023 with households accounting for 29%, manufacturing and processing at 31% and restaurants at 21%. Commercial sectors generate more than public narratives suggest (EPA, 2025).



Literature points to several tensions. Supply chain studies highlight cosmetic standards where retailers reject produce for colour or shape despite it being edible (de Hooge et al., 2018). Dominant solutions fall into two camps. Technology offers AI trackers for kitchens and portion control systems. Behavioural approaches push education apps and redistribution through groups like Food Cloud (Boraski, 2026).

Policy guidance exists through national roadmaps but lacks binding requirements for businesses (DCEE, 2025). This landscape sets up three dimensions for closer exploration. Kitchen preparation reveals structural routines. Consumer over ordering appears more visible. Supply chain rigidity operates furthest upstream. My deli work exposed the kitchen side to me while statistics revealed the full system at work. The main question becomes whether public focus on consumers overlooks power held by retailers and operators higher up the chain.

Mini Case 1 - Food Wastage in Kitchen Preparation

This happens when the likes of chefs and food handlers discard edible food during meal preparation by peeling vegetables and trimming meats. Studies have shown that avoidable waste like this actually accounts for the ~70% of the total food waste in the hospitality sector (Epresence, 2017). Unlike consumer waste, kitchen waste is structural and part of operational routines, where staff and infrastructure are simply not trained to deal with a variety of different food waste.

Food service waste actually costs the Irish hospitality industry €300 million annually (Foodwastecharter, 2025). This waste then also decomposes and produces methane gas, thus contributing negatively to climate change. Employees (like me at one point) also have to deal with a burden of disposing waste that they cannot prevent, while also seeing low-income communities having to deal with high prices and low availability of affordable food.

Attempts to address this are usually unsuccessful due to high up front costs (infrastructure and monthly subscriptions for AI trackers, which only high end and large businesses can afford (Winnow Solutions Ltd, 2026)), time constraints during busy

periods and improper infrastructure and flexibility (kitchens may lack storage capabilities for surplus food items, or do not have flexibility in their menus to use these leftovers).

Other reasons for the failure to address this issue lie in education and policy, where workers in the food industry are rarely trained for food wastage (I was not) and policies introduced by the government don't require these businesses to take action immediately and instead set targets such as 2030 for something that could easily be improved quickly (DCEE, 2025).

Mini Case 2 – Over Ordering by Consumers

This occurs when consumers purchase more than they can consume. This can be driven by promotions (buy one get one free, etc), a pressure to order variety, portion size unawareness and for social media content. Unlike the kitchen waste which is generally hidden from the consumers sight that was previously mentioned, over ordering is visible as consumers see how much they don't consume.

Only small amounts of commercial food waste actually reach food banks, where it is used to food impoverished communities. It is clear that large amounts of this vital resource are wasted, when it could be feeding poverty-stricken individuals.

Attempts to reduce waste here tend to fail at scale due to businesses prioritising profits from volume sales, “abundance” being seen as better in social settings, promotion structures and minimal policies on portion labelling and waste reporting (Caldeira et al., 2019).

Here we can see a contrast between case 1 and case 2, where now the consumer holds all the power in whether they will purchase more than they need. Businesses will try to influence these consumers as much as possible for a financial gain.

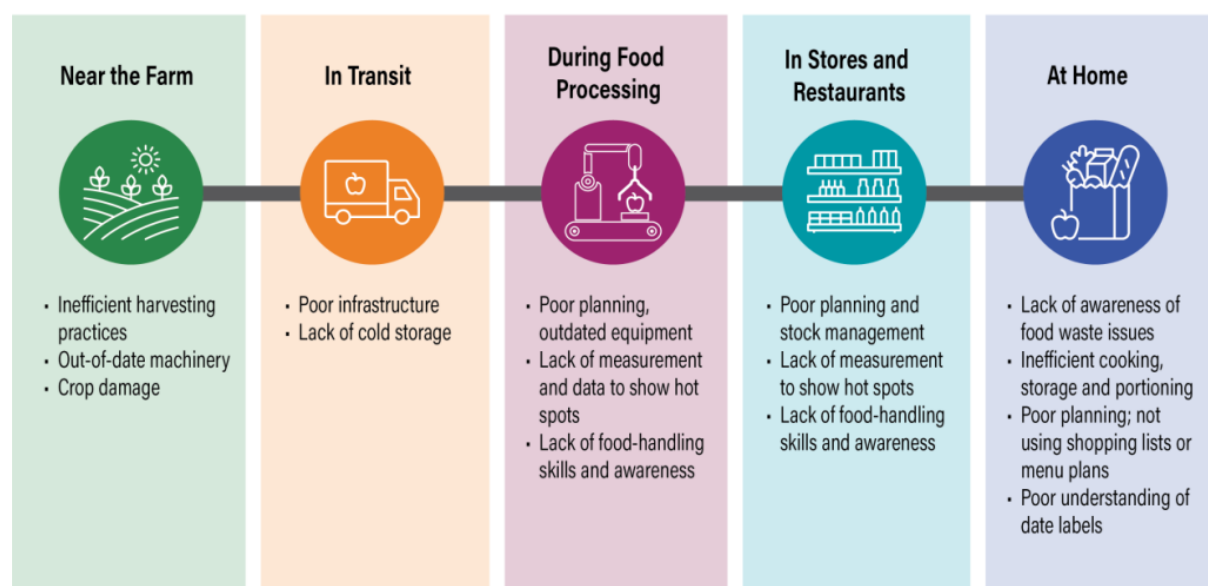
Mini Case 3 – Supply Chain Rigidity

This problem arises from inflexible contracts, cosmetic standards and poor logistics. We can see this through the example of farmers, who generally over produce goods to meet volume contracts.

Retailers can also reject for minor blemishes such as colour that don't affect the quality of the produce. Here we can see that there may be a lack of availability to redirect "rejected" edible food (Caldeira et al., 2019).

Solutions like that of AI powered traceability technology and donation incentives are stalled by retailers as it is not incentivised.

Compared to the previous two cases, this problem is largely found with the relationship between producer/supplier and the stores/restaurants.



Similarities and Differences

Kitchen preparation stands out as most structurally embedded. Over preparation peeling and trimming form core operational routines that staff cannot easily change without menu redesign training or equipment upgrades. This dimension generates commercial scale waste measured in tens of thousands of tonnes annually while remaining invisible to consumers and policymakers. Consumer over ordering depends

on kitchen surplus reaching plates in the first place. Supply chain rejection creates the initial excess that flows downstream.

Supply chain rigidity receives least attention in public discourse and policy. Farmers face cosmetic rejections and inflexible contracts yet rarely feature in waste conversations dominated by household and restaurant stats. Kitchen waste hides within operations. Consumer waste proves visible on plates and in bins. Upstream farm losses stay unseen before produce even reaches retail.

Supply chain rigidity also presents the greatest practical challenge. Retailers hold buying power to enforce cosmetic standards and volume contracts. Changing these requires renegotiated commercial agreements rebuilt buyer trust and potentially higher purchase prices passed to consumers. Kitchen solutions face cost barriers but remain within single business control. Consumer behaviour shifts through education pricing nudges and apps. Retailer incentives align least with waste reduction.

These dimensions connect systemically. Farm overproduction feeds kitchen over preparation which enables consumer over ordering. Each stage reinforces the next through structural incentives rather than individual failure. Kitchen operations feel most compelling because they bridge invisible upstream losses with visible consumer impact while carrying measurable economic weight. This reflection reveals how consumer focused solutions address symptoms while structural changes target causes. The question remains whether businesses controlling each stage possess incentives to disrupt their own profitable waste patterns.

Rights Trace v1

Farmers have their rights to fair work infringed upon. This is due to the rejection of goods produced due to imperfection and then no compensation for losses being given.

Workers that deal with food wastage regularly also suffer from the infringement of their rights to an ethical work environment. A feeling of guilt may present itself to these workers, but they have no decision-making input into what is done with this wastage.

Low-income households are also affected through their loss of a right to food. The inflated prices that result from food wastage and limited access to any food surplus really affect this group of people.

Future generations are also affected through their rights to a healthy environment and climate stability. Food wastage has a negative effect on the climate.

None of these primary rights holders truly get considered when decisions are made on this matter. This is largely due to large retailers, food processors and food service operators having so much control over their goods. They dictate prices, define standards and take no real action against wastage. In Ireland, organisations such as EPA and departments within the government only really provide guidance and don't set any immediate requirements in terms of food wastage. Food banks and charities are the only ones taking real action against this issue by advocating change and redistributing food surplus to those who need it most, but they even depend on many companies working with them out of their own goodness.

Sprint Pack

Transition from Foundations Pack

In my Foundations Pack, I analysed food waste across the Irish supply chain, highlighting how factors such as farm overproduction, kitchen routines and consumer behaviour interact to create systemic issues rather than solely individual problems. I examined three key areas: waste during kitchen preparation, visible overordering by consumers and rigidity within the supply chain. I also explored how these elements reinforce each other through existing incentives and power dynamics. Tensions were identified between public narratives that attribute responsibility to households and evidence indicating that commercial operations and retailers have significant influence. Additionally, I considered the balance between technological solutions and low cost operational changes. Moving forward into this sprint, I aim to focus on a specific leverage point within the system, particularly related to kitchen operations and business responsibilities, to facilitate the development of practical, targeted interventions rather than remaining at the broader critique level.

Identification of Two Contenders

Contender A: Kitchen Preparation Waste

Kitchen preparation waste occurs when chefs and food handlers discard edible food due to practices such as overpeeling, excessive trimming and overproduction integrated into daily routines. This preventable waste accounts for a significant portion of hospitality food waste and results in financial losses and unnecessary emissions, often unseen by consumers and policymakers alike. In my perspective, this area is particularly promising for analysis because it is within the control of the business, offers practical interventions (staff training, menu optimisation and low cost tracking methods), rather than solely relying on more expensive solutions. I could see how this issue could be resolved from my first-hand experience working in a deli. Additionally, it serves as a strategic point that connects food surplus to the food served to consumers, providing opportunities for impactful intervention. Stakeholders affected include

kitchen staff, who confront the burden of food waste, and low income households, who miss out on potential access to surplus food. Key decision makers involve managers, owners and policy agencies, which currently depend on voluntary guidelines to address these issues.

Contender B: Supply Chain Rigidity

Here supply chain rigidity refers to inflexible contracts, strict cosmetic standards and inefficient logistics that result in farmers overproducing and subsequently witnessing perfectly edible produce being rejected. This dynamic generates significant hidden waste before food reaches consumers and places farmers under unfair terms while contributing to environmental pressures caused by overproduction. From an analytical perspective, this issue is also promising as it highlights power imbalances between farmers and retailers. This includes the rights concerning fair labour and climate stability, and challenges the common narrative that food waste is primarily a consumer problem. Addressing this challenge is more complex, as effective solutions require constant renegotiation of agreements and aligning retailer incentives, rather than implementing isolated operational improvements. Key rights holders include farmers and future generations impacted by environmental effects and financial losses, while influential parties include supermarkets, processors and government entities.

Core Comparison Table

Comparison Criteria	A. Kitchen Preparation Waste	B. Supply Chain Rigidity	Analytical Insight
Conceptual clarity of the dimension	The concept of this contender is clear, easily described and observable within the kitchen. The practises which lead to this contender taking place are also clearly defined (mainly excess trimming and over production).	This contender is slightly more complex as it stretches across many different settings. The main components are cosmetic standards, logistics and contracts, which all have the possibility to lead to food wastage (especially in the example of a farmer).	Both are quite clear, but contender A is more concrete, which makes it a lot easier to identify specific practises and decisions, rather than many different areas of the supply chain.
Depth and complexity of the systems and reinforcing loops	Contains obvious loops of over preparation and routine wastage. There is not much depth and complexity here though as the issue is widespread but can be identified easily.	This contender is much more complex, with multiple layers of the supply chain interlinking. Where price pressures, cosmetic standards and overproduction all put	Where contender B offers much greater complexity and depth, it offers a much more difficult task in being able to link all these issues together. On the

		pressure onto producers. This rigidity is embedded within many different markets.	other hand contender A displays less complexity and depth, but can be easily identified.
Clarity of the relationship between rights-holders and power-actors, and power differences	Kitchen staff and low income households are the rights-holders, managers and owners are power-actors. This relationship is not initially visible but exists. Where staff are given no other option, and households cannot avail of the wasted goods.	Producers (like farmers) and future generations are right-holders, and large corporations and policymakers are the power-actors. Rights-holders have no say in policies and standards set be the power-actors.	The power differences are much clearer in contender B, where producers and future generations have no say in policies set by policymakers and large corporations. On the other hand, contender A offers an interesting view of responsibility that is held. This offers a better link between decisions and impacts.
Evidence base / knowledge anchors available to study the dimension from	There are many studies from the hospitality sector, audits for wastage and my own experience that I can gather information from.	There are also many reports made on the extent of food wastage due to the individual areas of cosmetic standards, logistics and contracts. Finding links for these could be somewhat difficult.	Contender A aligns much better with this assignment as there are more clear studies done that encompass kitchen wastage. Finding articles based on a single issue that encompass different aspects of supply chains would be extremely difficult.
Feasibility of intervention exploration	Very realistic interventions could be put in place. Such as staff training for waste awareness, changing menus to minimise wastage, increased tracking and taking suggestions from staff.	This is much more difficult to explore as there are many different areas to consider. This would lead to more hypothetical ideas rather than making grounded suggestions.	Contender A definitely enables a clearer and more feasible route for intervention exploration. These interventions can be envisioned better, rather than a hypothetical approach that would need to be taken for contender B.
Risk of superficial treatment	There is somewhat of a risk of superficial treatment if I focus in on one specific intervention too much. I also have to consider deeper organisational characteristics such as	There is a very high risk of superficial treatment here as I must consider many different areas of the issues faced here. For example, I cannot simply get rid of cosmetic standards as this will	Both contenders require careful analysis. Contender A gives more room to move beyond just identifying the issue. Contender B is more likely to lead to the

	workload, pricing and incentives.	produce new and much worse issues. I must balance opinions and factual information.	identification of more issues.
Personal intellectual commitment	I have direct experience with kitchen wastage through working at a deli. This has led to me having an interest and having a genuine curiosity in how changes could be made to minimise waste.	I have a small, if any, personal link to this contender. I am interested in this after watching a news segment a few years ago on large amounts of milk being dumped due to cosmetic standards not being met. It has made me question why such can produce just not be repurposed.	I have a larger connection to contender A in this instance. Contender A will allow me to apply reflections and generate original insights along with evidence gathered from various sources. In comparison, I have a minimal connection to contender B which may lead me to be less interested in this topic. With contender B I would use less reflective and critical thinking in this assignment.
Transformative potential of further exploration	There is some potential for transformation, through changing the kitchen from a waste producer to a space that minimises it and takes pride in doing so. This would not only transform the actions taken in the kitchen but also the public image of the business.	There is also potential for transformation here, through the analysis of where waste actually happens and why. This could develop into more complex topics such as fair pricing and contract negotiations. Although, any change would really be quite slow and indirect.	While contender B has much larger ambitions to how much change can actually happen, contender A supplies me with a much more grounded approach. With Contender A much more specific suggestions can be made.
Scale and measurability of impact	This generates tens of thousands of tonnes of waste annually in hospitality. Waste levels are actually measurable through weighing food bins, thus identifying how much emissions are being saved.	This would be much more difficult to measure without large amounts of industry data. Milk wastage for one could be measured but actual prevention levels are a bit more difficult to determine.	Contender A immediately offers much better impact measurability. Concrete measurements would be able to be taken, and the level of impact would be measurable. Contender B on the other hand is a much more complex situation, where it would be difficult to measure all the levels of supply chain and any impact that

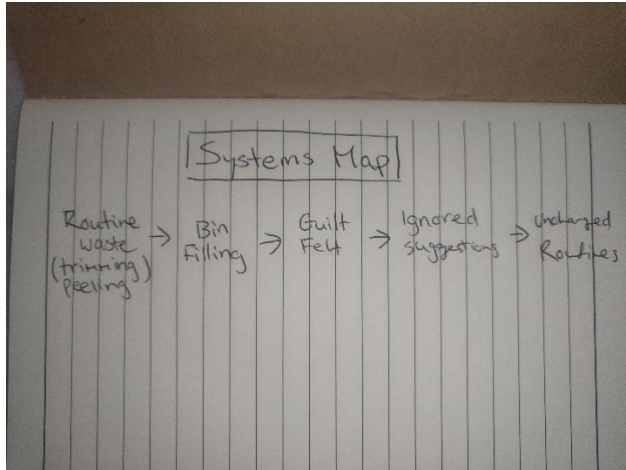
			changes have on the broader aspect of operations.
Alignment with policy landscape	This would align with roadmaps that already exist. Food wastage in hospitality is a large issue that is always being confronted.	Policies here exist but have targets set 10-20 years from now, so immediate change would be extremely difficult to build on. This would lead to any suggestions being speculative and not measurable.	Interventions in contender A would be much easier to envision and implement as there are already many cases of action being taken to minimise it. Contender B would really end up being hypothetical once again, with minimal action actually being able to be taken.
Ethical dimensions	This directly addresses ethical issues with kitchen food wastage. Staff will have less guilt burdened on them for food wastage, and low income individuals would be able to avail of donations of sorts.	Ethical issues are also addressed here as farmers' rights are strengthened through proper compensation for unavoidable wastage. Future generations are also at a benefit through potential increase in climate stability.	Both contenders have ethical dimensions deeply ingrained. Where rights-holders are empowered and not placed under unnecessary guilt, stress or financial losses.

Decision and Justification

Based on the comparison table, I will prioritise Contender A: Kitchen Preparation Waste. Analytically, this option is stronger due to its clearly defined scope, a substantial evidence base drawn from many cases and my experience in the deli sector and its high feasibility for implementing targeted micro-interventions such as staff training or waste tracking. It allows for precise systems mapping without the complexity associated with supply chains. The trade-offs include focusing at the operational level (kitchens) rather than pursuing a larger change, which may limit broader systemic impact, and the potential risk of superficial solutions centered on raising awareness if organisational incentives are not adequately addressed. Through this analysis, I have learned that personal proximity enhances reflection and practicality, and that small-scale work is more effective when it emphasises designing routines that foster fairness and support surplus redistribution to low-income households. This decision aligns with my motivation, stemming from personal experiences with waste and a desire to develop practical, concrete and rights-based solutions.

Building Block Progression

Systems Map



Narrowed to kitchen preparation waste, we can focus on hospitality operations.

Loop: Routine waste (Excess trimming and peeling) → Bin filling of some avoidable waste → Staff feel guilt → Occasional suggestions ignored on minimisation → Unchanged routines lead to the cycle starting again.

Updated Rights-Trace (v2)

Building on v1 (farmers' fair work, workers' ethical environment, low-income food access, future climate stability), v2 focuses on kitchen context.

Core rights-holders:

- Kitchen workers (right to dignified work without waste guilt)
- Low income households (right to surplus food via donations)

Power-actors:

- Managers (enforce no donation rules and rigid routines for profit/safety)

Power gap:

- Staff lack input despite burden and charities like Food Cloud depend on goodwill. Interventions must prioritise worker voice and equitable redistribution, not just cost savings.

Early version of Interventions

For an test intervention scenario I would conduct a 1 week pilot "Kitchen Waste Tracker" in a small deli or hotel kitchen

Steps:

1. Train 5 staff on categorising waste (peels, trims, over-preparation) via simple bin labels.
2. Daily weigh-ins and log photos
3. Identify areas for menu tweaks (e.g. smaller portions or find ways to use peels/trims).

Justice guardrails: Design this pilot with staff input, try to commit at least 20% recovered surplus to Food Cloud.

Measures: Reduction of waste (target 30% reduction), conduct staff surveys on their job satisfaction levels (specifically to do with food wastage) and track the level of food wastage being donated/repurposed.

Challenges: Busy shifts and management input would pose problems. This tests the feasibility while advancing rights.

Reflection on Sprint Process

Between Foundations and Sprint stages, I transitioned from a broad mapping of the supply chain across multiple dimensions to a more targeted analysis of kitchen preparation waste as my primary focus. This shift allowed me to move from systemic critique to identifying actionable interventions. My initial inclination towards addressing kitchen waste was influenced by my experience as a deli worker, but the comparison table reinforced this choice. While supply chain rigidity presented additional complexity, it proved to be analytically challenging and less practical for this assignment.

Uncertainties remain regarding the scalability of kitchen interventions, particularly in relation to potential management resistance and concerns over liability that may hinder donations. The comparison exercise was particularly challenging, as quantifying trade-offs forced me to prioritise critically. This process highlighted how personal closeness to specific issues often drives sustained reflection more than abstract structural arguments. Overall, this phase strengthened my confidence in maintaining a focused, rights-based approach within defined boundaries.

FOCUSED BUILD

Bridge

Through insights gained from the Sprint pack, where I compared the issues of kitchen preparation wastage and supply chain rigidity, I have been able to identify that kitchen food preparation waste is clearly the strongest lens. This issue is clearly grounded, and I have relevant personal experience with it. In my analysis I was able to clearly see that rigid operational routines are what causes food wastage to happen on large scales. The main assumption that I am carrying into Stage 3 is based on the idea that management and owners of established resist changing operation techniques to solve this food wastage. This stems from the idea that employees that are faced with dealing with food wastage in a hands-on environment have no other options, as they cannot change operations themselves, e.g. introducing donations or redesigning menus to be more flexible.

Deepening Dimensions

Kitchen preparation waste in Ireland shouldn't be looked at as an issue that is directly caused by the employee handling the food, but it should be looked at as an underlying failure of organisational strategy. Employees have to work within the rules that are set by their employer, which are all designed to increase efficiency and maintain standards. In my experience and through various lived voices some examples of these rules include that you must overprepare "in case" it is busy during a certain time, throw out stock that is still perfectly edible just to move inventory and serve fresher food, and make visual examples of the food being served with actual fresh produce that will just get thrown out at the end of the shift. These are not things that employees essentially have control over but instead have been trained to do with no alternatives.

Food service waste costs the Irish hospitality industry €300 million annually, with avoidable waste accounting for much of this (Foodwastecharter, 2025). Even with this issue, policies still allow it to happen. We can see this firsthand in Ireland's National Food Waste Prevention Roadmap which only sets targets for 2030 and doesn't set any immediate objectives for food service operators to aim for (DCEE, 2025). Similarly, the 'Farm to Fork' strategy, which encompasses overall food sustainability levels to ensure that everybody has access, set up by the European Commission in 2020, only sets long term targets that have no current obligations or at the very least annual targets. The fact that minimal plans and recommendations have been made, and no legislative frameworks have even been proposed 6 years later highlights the issues that Ireland and the EU are facing today (European Commission, 2020).

Lived voices reinforce this idea that there is minimal action being taken to address food sustainability issues. A former deli colleague confirmed that little has changed with respect to operations since I worked there nearly 4 years ago and "if anything, it

has gotten worse". High staff turnover leads to poor training of new employees, which doesn't help sustainable food practices. This lived voice also said that she had suggested that professional food training courses were provided for new employees to gain a better understanding of how to maximise sustainability, but this suggestion was simply "too costly" to take forward (Anonymous Lived Voice, March 2026).

Another lived voice, who recently started his new role as a commis chef after getting certified, stated that he agreed that food waste reduction receives almost no meaningful attention in professional culinary training. There were two OPTIONAL programs that he was aware of that of in Ireland, the WASTED Initiative and Savour Food e-Training, which are both modular online sessions don't allow you to ask questions, are overly basic and cover topics that are already known through "common sense" (Anonymous Lived Voice, March 2026). Approximately 30 minutes of e-learning is clearly not a good enough answer to address the underlying problems associated with kitchen food wastage. This aligns with assumptions that indicate that employees working with the food possess significant awareness of high waste actions, but are excluded from any decision making when it comes to these actions (Nand et al., 2025).

While companies may consider donating food, it is understandable why some choose not to as well. Currently, food donators specifically aren't covered by any "Good Samaritan Laws" that exist elsewhere, which means that businesses who donate surplus food are fully liable for any issues regarding their donations (FSAI, 2025). Apps such as Too Good To Go offer partial workarounds by allowing businesses to sell surplus food at heavy discounts and go around a lot of the liability issues that are associated with donations. This observation could be a strong indication as to why this model has seen over 590,000 people in Ireland use this platform (McEvoy, 2024).

These lived voices and observation deepen the systems. The initial action loop that was identified in the Sprint stage (routine waste -> guilt -> ignored suggestions -> unchanged routines) isn't just a communication failure but is encouraged by an organisational culture that treats food wastage as an unavoidable cost rather than a operational and ethical failure. Training is only optional and inadequate anyway, suggestions by employees get dismissed for being too costly and various policies surrounding food wastage don't put immediate pressure on businesses to improve sustainability in smaller increments. It can also be seen that Too Good To Go demonstrated that where there are incentives, businesses will definitely engage and support waste reduction. The downside to this is that the surplus only reaches paying customers, while they are discounted it doesn't mean that households that suffer from poor food security can avail of these services. The liability gap is highlighted as a significant barrier to surplus redistribution efforts, and Ireland needs to introduce some protections for businesses that want to donate.

Rights Trace v3

The Rights Trace largely remains the same as the previous version, just with expansions on ideas from literature and live voices.

Core Rights-Holders

- Kitchen Workers: Have the right to dignified and guilt free work but is violated when staff cannot prevent constant food wastage. Lived voices confirm that these observations are constant and are frustrating as there is no alternatives given.
- Low Income Households: The right to food is compromised by legal and operational barriers that prevent surplus food to be distributed to those who need it the most. While organisations that do exist for food distribution purposes, only small fractions reach those who need it.

Power Actors

- Managers and Owners: They enforce no donation rules and rigid routines for profit and safety concerns. This absence of protection for donations means that those who avoid risk would rather throw their waste out than donate it.

Government departments, specifically the DCEE (Department of Climate, Energy and the Environment) and FSAI (Food Safety Authority of Ireland), hold the power to close these gaps but have not done so.

Systems Map v2



Intervention Canvas

Design

The intervention that I propose, would be a structured Waste Reduction and Redistribution program, which can be implemented easily and at low cost for small and medium hospitality businesses (this would include cafes, delis, hotels, etc.). The program would be effective through the use of an approach with two distinct components.

For the first component of this program I would introduce a structured audit that takes place every day across one month. Here we would measure waste production by category by separating the waste into distinct categories in separate bins. The categories would include peelings/trimmings, over-produced goods that have went to waste and any returns received. Every day/shift the amount of waste output should be recorded through a simple log sheet or online. Each week for four weeks, management alongside employees should identify the biggest contributor to wastage and attempt to introduce an idea to reduce the waste for the next week. This could be through a menu change, for instance potato peels could be used for a dish with potato skins, or certain trimmings and peels could be used for soup, or even a reduction in standard batch sizes during food preparation. This ensures that employees are listened to and operational efficiency is increased.

For the second component, I would have these businesses register with Food Cloud or any other redistribution platform to ensure that edible food that is still there by the end of the shift will be packaged and collected for donations. These businesses could also take additional optional approaches to further reduce wastage through clearance stickers for food that has been sitting out for a certain period of time (similar to those used by supermarkets like Tesco) and also having these be available to order through

services such as Too Good To Go. This ensures that businesses don't suffer significant financial losses from over donation, and that only food that have went through clearance efforts already with no sale will be donated rather than thrown out.

Justification

These interventions are based on three core principles that I have been able to identify through the process of this diary. The first of which is that staff that have direct contact with the food wastage have the most knowledge of where it happens, suggestions of how to prevent it and other aspects that go unnoticed by management. Then there is the identification of the liability issues with donations, as companies are unwilling to potentially be punished for donating their food. These businesses are faced with an issue where if they do something ethical it comes with risk, but just throwing out the goods presents no legal and minimal financial risk. I was also able to identify that intervention is more doable at the kitchen level than supply chain or consumer level because it is within the control of the business and doesn't require supply chain processes or convincing the mass public to change their behaviour.

Measures

Measuring the effectiveness of the interventions should not pose an issue and can be done through a combination of three ways. First, weekly food waste weight by category should be measured, with a target of 10% reduction in the first 4 weeks. This estimation is based on similar pilot programs that have taken place in the UK, where some businesses saw reductions of up to 62% within 8 weeks. The average waste reduction annually was at just over 17%, which means that a target of 10% in 1 month may look high but the first weeks and months are the most effective in eliminating easy

to avoid waste with waste reduction (WRAP, 2021). Secondly, I would record the amount of clearance items that were successfully sold along with the amount that was successfully donated through organisations such as Food Cloud. Lastly, I would like to receive continuous updates from stakeholders (employees, managers, customers) on how they feel about any new processes introduced. This would include things like do you feel like your suggestions are heard, whether guilt about food wastage has reduced, has satisfaction with processes increased, and do these new implementations encourage you to shop here more often. With that continuous and incremental goals would be set to decrease wastage in target areas that need more attention.

Challenges

Obvious challenges exist in order for these interventions to take place. Managers must be willing to be part of this journey, but those with thin margins may just see this plan as a burden on organisational efficiency. To address this actions such as keeping the tracking system to a bare minimum (one daily weight being entered and not continuous updates) and framing it in a way that sets up long term cost savings (as waste reduction eventually leads to reductions in amounts of food needing to be purchased and thus cost savings).

Another obvious challenge that I see as one that is underlying is that staff may simply forget or not have time to give updates during busy periods. I remember times when the deli was extremely busy and normal practises had to be sacrificed for time savings and efficiency because at the end of day serving customers is the priority. The fix to this is being flexible and not portraying this process as a burden put on employees, so

continuous updates should only be given once work with a higher priority is completed first.

The liability concern over donations is one that is more difficult to fix as the power of change directly lies in the hands of authorities such as FSAI (Food Standard Authority of Ireland). The last challenge that would need to be overcome is the scaling of these interventions to be a national standard. Similarly to the concerns over liability, the power of change directly lies in the hands of authorities that set guidelines and standards.

Justice Guardrails

For the design and efficient implementation of this intervention the following justice guardrails need to be non-negotiable:

- An aim of at least 15% of identified surplus needs to be directed to the redistribution organisations (Food Cloud or equivalent) and not retained for clearance sale or employee take home. This guarantees that the most vulnerable rights holders receive sufficient benefits from the intervention.
- The participation in waste audits and debriefs is voluntary and employees are assessed using them. Workers who raise concerns cannot be penalised by management. Essentially a contract of sorts needs to be signed to ensure that employees are not affected by any opinions they voice or suggestions they make.

Personal Reflection

Through this diary I have been able to better understand how the relationship between personal experiences and structured analysis work in practise. Initially I was able to identify that food wastage is wrong and should be minimised through my own personal experience. Through close analysis I now understand that issues go much deeper than the surface and there are clear structural barriers that stand in the way of change. Moving from the initial observation to a closer analysis to then designing an intervention taught me that something that looks like a viable and simple solution on the surface can have deeper processes, structures and rules that make it difficult for these solutions to take place.

This module was able to give me a clear framework that allowed me to build logical thoughts and make everything clearer. For example, the Rights Trace forced me to focus on who is being harmed, who holds the power and who can make changes happen, which is a simple way of looking at things that may be overlooked in many situations but are very important for a proper analysis. The Systems Map also allowed me to envision how each issue flows into the next, rather than being solitary issues. I plan to carry this development of clear and analytical thinking into any leadership context I find myself in (could be management, logistics or simply questioning decisions).

I think that throughout this degree I have been given assignments that enable my deeper thinking of subjects that I would not encounter normally. As a future leader I will be able to enable this new way of thinking that I have developed throughout my studies. The concept of basing a decision on what is perceived from the get-go is one that I have learned to stop doing, although sometimes initial opinions and observations

turn out to be correct, and I have moved forward with more critical and analytical way of thinking in my daily life.

Future Outlook

When it comes to the issue of food wastage, I believe that I am somewhat optimistic about the future. Ireland's trajectory points in the direct direction, through EPA paying more attention to food wastage data, companies like Food Cloud growing and aiming for their goals of eliminating unnecessary food wastage and EU targets are nearing their intended implementation dates. The direction is right, but the pace is obviously too slow, and this makes progress stall.

The issue that is the largest cause of concern is large businesses in Ireland treating kitchen wastage as a way to improve operational efficiency rather than an ethical one. As long as waste reduction is framed as just a way of cost saving, deeper ethical issues will get ignored. Employees who regularly deal with the wastage and low-income households who could benefit from surplus food deserve to be the main concern, not ignored. Until policies actually begin to reflect on this, significant progress is limited.

With another 90 days I would pursue the growth of my analysis and intervention through various methods. I would begin with running small pilot in two locations (preferably a small café, deli or hotel restaurant), where I would run the initial first component and measure how employee suggestions and waste distribution has an effect on food wastage. I would then begin to reach out to FSAI or any other government authorities associated with consumable goods and try to push for a straightforward solution into removing liabilities that businesses face with food donations. I would also push for the incorporation of an industry wide food waste reduction standard into

awards and accreditations that businesses in this market can receive. This gives businesses an incentive to stand out from the rest in an ethical standpoint and allowing them to benefit in some way rather than no way.

From where this diary started, with me being frustrated with having to throw out so much food at the deli and not having influence in reducing it, to its ending with a designed strategic intervention plan with clear steps show that structured thinking and solutions can be developed from frustration.

Number	Source	Key Knowledge	Impact on Diary	Stage
1	EPA (2025) <i>Food Waste Statistics</i> . Available at: https://www.epa.ie/our-services/monitoring--assessment/waste/national-waste-statistics/food/ (Accessed: 25 January 2026).	Ireland generated 835,000 tonnes of food waste in 2023 (162kg per person). Commercial sectors (manufacturing (31%) and restaurants (21%)) match or exceed household waste (29%). Hospitality loses €300 million annually.	Overturned initial assumption that waste is primarily a consumer problem. Established the economic and statistical anchor for the entire diary. Elevated kitchen operations as commercially significant and policy relevant.	Foundations
2	<i>The Value of Food Waste</i> Iseult Ward TEDxHa’pennyBridge (2017). Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YO-WKeKMxrl (Accessed: 28 January 2026).	Ireland wastes 1 million tonnes annually while 1 in 8 people face food insecurity. Food Cloud has redistributed surplus from 1,000+ businesses to 3,600 charities, delivering 12 million meals.	Brought a human rights dimension to abstract statistics. Confirmed redistribution is technically feasible but depends on corporate goodwill. Strengthened the low-income household rights-holder in the Rights Trace. Shifted focus from consumer behaviour toward structural distribution barriers.	Foundations
3	Frost, A. (2023) ‘The woe of wasted milk’, <i>Sustainable Food Trust</i> , 22 March. Available at: https://sustainablefoodtrust.org/news-views/the-woe-of-wasted-milk/ (Accessed: 1 February 2026).	Dairy farmers receive below-cost prices yet must keep producing due to loan obligations. Market oversupply leads to surplus milk being downgraded or discarded despite being drinkable. Farmers carry risk while retailers hold pricing power.	Deepened the supply chain rigidity dimension with a concrete Irish product example. Strengthened the farmers' fair work rights argument in Rights Trace v1. Linked overproduction to environmental pressure from maintaining large herds unnecessarily.	Foundations
4	Epresence (2017) ‘Hoteliers Tackle Food Waste’, <i>Green Hospitality</i> , 2 March. Available at: https://greenhospitality.ie/hoteliers-tackle-food-waste/ (Accessed: 30 January 2026).	Irish hoteliers achieved 30–50% waste reductions using low-cost methods such as portion control, recipe standardisation, staff training and charity partnerships. Vegetable peelings and meat trimmings identified as primary contributors.	Confirmed that kitchen waste reduction is achievable without expensive AI technology. Shifted solution barriers from difficult to accessible. Provided Irish-specific evidence supporting the intervention design. Demonstrated that workers can move from waste disposers to active reducers, improving job dignity.	Foundations
5	Rotten (Netflix, 2018, Season 1, Episode 5: Milk Money) (Accessed: 12 February 2026)	Corporate consolidation in the U.S. dairy industry creates market pressures that drive overproduction, squeezing small family farms. Media often focuses on sensationalised narratives rather than structural power imbalances.	Reinforced the supply chain rigidity dimension from an international comparative perspective. Highlighted how media framing can obscure structural causes which is a useful contrast with Ireland's similarly voluntary policy environment. Supported the argument that power imbalances between small producers and large corporations are a recurring global pattern.	Sprint
6	Waste Watchers (RTÉ One, 2014) https://vimeo.com/84029174 (Accessed: 16 February 2026)	Irish households, retailers and food service operators across a small town quantified their edible food disposal. Overbuying, bulk promotions, poor fridge management and date label confusion were primary drivers.	Reinforced that waste is not solely a commercial or supply chain issue but instead a behavioural factors across households and retail also contribute. Shifted framing toward shared accountability. Supported the consumer over-ordering mini case in Foundations and confirmed that effective reduction requires incentive changes, not just awareness campaigns.	Sprint
7	Thompson, S. (Aug 03, 2025) Counting the cost of food waste: ‘People don’t have enough to eat not due to lack of production, but lack of access’, <i>The Irish Times</i> . Available at: https://www.irishtimes.com/life-style/people/2025/08/03/counting-the-cost-of-food-waste-people-dont-have-enough-to-eat-not-due-to-lack-of-production-but-lack-of-access/ (Accessed: 20 February 2026).	Ireland's food waste costs €1.29 billion annually (€700 per household). Food Cloud redistributed 3,900 tonnes last year. Calls exist for Good Samaritan laws, tax credits and mandatory donation similar to France's Garot Law.	Confirmed that liability concerns are a documented barrier to redistribution, directly explaining why delis discard rather than donate. Provided the 1% redistribution figure as evidence of the scale of missed opportunity. Strengthened the justice guardrail and intervention justification around Good Samaritan protections in the Focused Build.	Sprint
8	Hunt, J. (Oct 13, 2025) We are throwing away about a month’s worth of grocery shopping every year, <i>The Irish Times</i> . Available at: https://www.irishtimes.com/life-style/people/2025/10/11/we-are-throwing-away-about-a-months-worth-of-grocery-shopping-every-year/ (Accessed: 24 February 2026).	Irish households discard approximately €850 of food annually (120kg per household). Over-production due to poor planning and portion control mirrors commercial kitchen patterns throughout the supply chain.	Demonstrated that household waste behaviours mirror commercial kitchen over-production, reinforcing that the problem is systemic across the entire food chain rather than isolated to one sector. Reinforced the rights argument that rising food costs driven by waste disproportionately harm low-income households, supporting the access dimension of the Rights Trace.	Sprint
9	WRAP (2021) <i>Food Waste Reduction Roadmap Progress Report 2021</i> , <i>WRAP - The Waste and Resources Action Programme</i> . Available at: https://www.wrap.ngo/resources/report/food-waste-reduction-roadmap-progress-report-2021 (Accessed: 1 March 2026).	140 businesses reduced food waste by 17% overall saving 251,000 tonnes worth £365 million. Hospitality sector data was unquantifiable due to insufficient reporting. Pilots recorded reductions of 23–38%, with one hotel even achieving a whopping 62% over four weeks.	Provided verified reduction benchmarks for the intervention measures section. The absence of hospitality data in WRAP's own report directly reinforced the systems map argument that kitchen waste operates unmeasured and unaccountable, framed by WRAP itself as one of the sector's most significant remaining challenges.	Focused
10	Anonymous Lived Voice 1 (March, 2026) Casual conversation with former deli colleague	Confirmed that operational practices have not meaningfully changed in the four years since I worked at the same deli. Staff turnover is high, new employees receive poor training and wastage has gotten worse rather than better. A suggestion she made to introduce professional food training for new staff was dismissed by management as too costly.	Directly confirmed the core systems loop identified in the Sprint, that suggestions from staff are dismissed and routines remain unchanged. Moved the loop from a theoretical argument to a lived reality. Also introduced high staff turnover as an additional reinforcing factor not previously identified, which was incorporated into the deepening dimensions section.	Focused
11	Cesaro, R. (2020) ‘Fighting food wastage – introduction to the French law’, <i>Zero Waste Consultant</i> , 19 June. Available at: https://zerowastecity.com/fighting-food-wastage-introduction-to-the-french-law/ (Accessed: 6 March 2026).	France has introduced three progressive food waste laws. Loi Aillagon (2003) introduced tax rebates of up to 60% for food donations. Loi Garot (2016) went further by legally obliging food retailers over 400m to establish donation agreements with redistribution organisations, with fines of up to €1,500 for non-compliance. Loi Egalim (2018) added mandatory CSR reporting on food wastage and designated responsible persons within businesses for donation management. Deliberate destruction of consumable food can result in a €3,750 fine.	This was the most significant comparative policy source in the diary. France demonstrates that legal obligation rather than voluntary participation is what drives redistribution at scale which is directly countering the Irish approach of roadmaps and optional targets. The fine for deliberately destroying consumable food is particularly relevant to the deli experience described throughout the diary, where edible food was binned by company policy. This source strengthened the intervention justification for pursuing Good Samaritan protections in Ireland and supported the future outlook argument that Ireland needs to move beyond voluntary frameworks. It also reinforced the rights argument that food-insecure households are failed by policy inaction when workable legislative models already exist elsewhere.	Focused

12	Garvey, M. (2025) ‘FoodCloud redistributed over 330 million meals since 2013’, <i>Echo.ie</i> , 1 August. Available at: https://www.echo.ie/foodcloud-redistributed-over-330-million-meals-since-2013/ (Accessed: 8 March 2026).	Since 2013 Food Cloud has redistributed over 140,000 tonnes of surplus food equivalent to 330 million meals, saving 425,000 tonnes of CO2 emissions. In Ireland alone during 2024, Food Cloud redistributed 3,896 tonnes through partnerships with 195 food businesses and 674 community organisations. The organisation has launched a One Billion Meals campaign targeting €25 million in funding by 2030. It currently operates three warehouse hubs and employs 92 staff supported by volunteers.	Provided verified up to date impact figures for Food Cloud directly from their financial report. The 3,896 tonnes redistributed in Ireland in 2024 is particularly significant, as when it is cross-referenced with Thompson (2025) which estimated 1% of potential being captured, this figure truly illustrates the scale of the redistribution gap that the liability barrier and voluntary business participation create. The 195 business partnerships also shows that engagement exists but remains far too limited relative to the size of the sector. Strengthened the justice guardrail argument that redistribution to food insecure households is feasible at scale when the right structures are in place and supported the future outlook case for expanding Food Cloud partnerships through the proposed intervention.	Focused
13	Nordic Council of Ministers <i>et al.</i> (2012) <i>Prevention of food waste in restaurants, hotels, canteens and catering</i> . Nordic Council of Ministers. Available at: https://doi.org/10.6027/TN2012-537 .	A study of 289 hospitality operators across Denmark, Finland, Norway and Sweden found that comprehensive measurement of food waste volumes is rare and many businesses lack precise data on avoidable waste. Total avoidable food waste from Nordic hospitality operations was estimated at 456,000 tonnes annually. Survey respondents prioritised portion control, staff training on cost awareness and menu planning as the most important future actions. Operators expressed low interest in government regulation, preferring voluntary approaches, yet the authors conclude that voluntary measures alone will be insufficient to meet ambitious reduction targets.	Provided significant comparative international evidence that the problems identified in the Irish context, like the absence of measurement, reliance on voluntary action and staff training gaps, which are not unique to Ireland but structural features of the hospitality sector across multiple countries. This strengthened the argument that voluntary roadmaps like Ireland's DCEE framework are predictably insufficient, as even Nordic countries with stronger sustainability cultures have found voluntary approaches fall short. The finding that operators resist regulation while researchers conclude regulation is necessary directly mirrors the tension at the centre of the diary's intervention design and future outlook sections.	Focused
14	Anonymous Lived Voice 2 (March, 2026) A casual conversation with a recently certified commis chef	Confirmed that food waste reduction receives almost no meaningful attention in professional culinary training. Identified two optional programmes available in Ireland (WASTED Initiative and Savour Food e-Training) describing both as overly basic, modular and unable to facilitate questions. Approximately 30 minutes of optional e-learning represents the extent of formal training available.	Strengthened the training inadequacy argument considerably by providing evidence from someone who had just completed the full certification process. The identification of the two optional programmes gave the diary concrete examples to critique rather than making a general claim about poor training. Directly supported the justice guardrail around mandatory staff engagement in the intervention design.	Focused
15	Dining In Dublin (2022) ‘GIY launch “WASTED” with some of Ireland’s Top Chefs on board Dining in Dublin Magazine’, 2 March. Available at: https://www.diningindublin.ie/giy-launch-wasted-with-some-of-irelands-top-chefs-on-board/ (Accessed: 18 March 2026).	WASTED is a free 8 lesson online programme launched by GIY in partnership with the EPA and DCEE targeting foodservice workers. It aims to address the 200,000 tonnes of food wasted annually in the Irish foodservice sector worth €300 million. The programme encourages participants to weigh waste before and after completing lessons to track improvement. It is entirely self-paced with no interactive element and culminates in an optional Wasted Supper Club event.	Provided concrete detail on one of the food waste training programs available to Irish hospitality workers, which strengthened the training critique in the deepening dimensions section. The programme is optional, self-paced and dependent on individual motivation rather than being embedded in any certification or operational requirement. This reinforced the argument that training in Ireland relies entirely on goodwill rather than structural obligation, which directly supports the intervention design and the justice guardrail around mandatory staff engagement.	Focused
16	Savour (2024) ‘Savour Food E-Training’. Available at: https://foodretail.savourfood.ie/courses/registration/ (Accessed: 18 March 2026).	Savour Food e-Training is a short online course aimed at staff in the food retail sector covering three lessons (titled: the big picture, basics of food waste, and staff guidance). It’s self paced, includes basic quizzes and issues a certificate of completion. The course is designed for retail staff broadly rather than being tailored to hospitality or kitchen-specific operations.	Confirmed what the lived voice described, that formal food waste training available in Ireland is brief, generic and not specific to the pressures of a commercial kitchen environment. The retail focus of the course is particularly notable given that my diary centres on hospitality and kitchen preparation waste, meaning the training is not even directly applicable to the sector generating the most avoidable waste. Combined with the WASTED entry, this paints a clear picture of an Irish training landscape that is entirely voluntary, basic and poorly matched to the operational realities of the foodservice sector. Both entries together strengthen the argument that mandatory, kitchen-specific training is needed rather than optional e-learning modules.	Focused
17	Yumitro, G., Oktaviani, S. and Deniar, S. (2024) ‘How South Korea’s waste management system becomes a model for the world: What Indonesia can learn from South Korea’s experience’, <i>Communications in Humanities and Social Sciences</i> , 4, pp. 22–28. Available at: https://doi.org/10.21924/chss.4.1.2024.71 .	South Korea operates a mandatory food waste separation and pay-as-you-throw system where households and businesses pay fees based on the weight of waste discarded, creating a direct financial incentive to reduce waste. This combined with strict enforcement and penalties has increased food waste recycling from approximately 2% to 95%. The system integrates source separation, economic instruments, infrastructure and citizen engagement rather than relying on any single voluntary measure.	Provided the strongest international comparative evidence in the diary for why voluntary frameworks fail and binding mechanisms succeed. South Korea's trajectory from 2% to 95% food waste recycling demonstrates what mandatory measurement, financial incentives and enforcement can achieve. A direct contrast to Ireland's voluntary roadmap approach with 2030 targets and no immediate obligations. The pay-as-you-throw model is particularly relevant as it creates the financial incentive for hospitality businesses that my diary identifies as currently missing. Strengthened the future outlook argument that Ireland needs to move beyond voluntary participation and supported the intervention design principle that businesses engage with waste reduction when there is a clear incentive to do so.	Focused
18	Sustainability Directory (no date) <i>How Does Food Waste Affect Mental Well-Being? → Question, Lifestyle → Sustainability Directory</i> . Available at: https://lifestyle.sustainability-directory.com/question/how-does-food-waste-affect-mental-well-being/ (Accessed: 22 March 2026).	Food waste creates measurable psychological harm including guilt, anxiety and stress which comes from the discomfort of acting against one's own values. In commercial settings, workers who witness repeated waste they cannot prevent experience a particular form of moral unease. The source looks into moral disengagement to explain how individuals and organisations rationalise wasteful behaviour by minimising its severity or blaming external factors. Consumer culture and social media standards of perfection further normalise waste by encouraging rejection of imperfect produce.	Provided the academic grounding for the staff guilt argument that runs throughout the diary, which until this entry relied primarily on my own lived voice evidence. The moral disengagement concept is directly applicable to management behaviour in the diary as businesses rationalise binning edible food by citing liability concerns or operational efficiency rather than confronting the ethical consequences. This strengthened the rights trace argument that kitchen workers suffer a dignified work violation when forced to act against their own values daily with no alternative available to them. Also reinforced why awareness-based interventions alone are insufficient as moral disengagement means people already know waste is wrong but have rationalised continuing anyway.	Focused

19	<i>Wasted! The Story of Food Waste</i> (2017). Zero Point Zero Production Inc.	Globally 1.3 billion tonnes of food is wasted annually at a cost of \$1 trillion. In the United States 40% of produce is discarded and over 90% of food waste ends up in landfill where anaerobic decomposition produces methane. The documentary uses the EPA food waste hierarchy to frame priority uses of food resources which are human consumption first, then animal feed, then composting, with landfill as the least acceptable outcome. Star chefs and food activists demonstrate how surplus and undesirable cuts can be transformed into innovative dishes, arguing that waste reduction does not require specialist skills and is achievable at household and commercial level alike.	Provided global scale figures that contextualised the Irish statistics used throughout the diary within a broader international crisis. The EPA food waste hierarchy model directly informed the intervention design section, reinforcing the principle that redistribution to food-insecure households must take priority over other uses of surplus (which underpins the 15% redistribution justice guardrail). The documentary's focus on chefs as agents of change rather than sources of waste complemented the lived voice evidence from the commis chef, strengthening the argument that culinary professionals are willing to engage with waste reduction when given the tools and permission to do so. The methane figure reinforced the climate rights argument in the Rights Trace.	Focused
20	<i>Just Eat It: A Food Waste Story (FULL MOVIE)</i> (2020). Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KUHdTDwdq8U (Accessed: 29 March 2026).	Two filmmakers lived entirely on discarded food for six months, finding over \$1,000 worth of food in their first month alone while spending just \$33. The documentary reveals that cosmetic standards drive enormous upstream waste (one peach farmer reported between 20% and 70% of produce discarded for appearance alone despite being perfectly edible). A supermarket manager confirmed that close-dated food goes straight to landfill due to liability fears despite a Good Samaritan Act existing in the US providing legal protection for donors. Date label confusion causes approximately 60% of consumers to discard food prematurely. The film also highlights a host culture of abundance, where running out of food is considered more embarrassing than wasting it which directly mirrors commercial kitchen over-preparation logic.	Reinforced multiple dimensions of the diary simultaneously. The cosmetic standards finding strengthened the supply chain rigidity argument from the Foundations Pack. The supermarket manager's liability fear despite existing US legal protection directly parallels the Irish liability gap identified in the Focused Build and the film's expert noting this fear is largely unfounded strengthened the argument that a Good Samaritan framework in Ireland would work in practice. The host culture abundance finding provided strong cultural evidence for why commercial kitchens systematically over-prepare, grounding what had previously been argued structurally in a recognisable social norm.	Focused

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Guarantee of Ethics & Data Care Template

I undertake that I have anonymized the identities of individuals and organizations I collected primary data from and/or quoted in the assignment, unless express permission has been obtained from the relevant individuals or organizations to disclose their details in the assignment. I understand that this does not apply to other sources in the public domain from which I obtain information, such as interviews and talks on publicly available sources, TED talks and expert interviews telecasted by news channels, published academic articles, websites of organizations, datasets, annual reports and reports published in popular press or other similar sources, etc.

Student name: Martinas Jucys Brady

Dated: 10/04/2026

Use of AI Disclosure Template

You may use DCU authorized Generative AI tools to assist with certain tasks in this module. You are allowed to only use Google Gemini or Microsoft Auto-Pilot logged into through your DCU ID to adhere to the privacy and security policies of DCU. Any content or ideas generated by Gen AI that are incorporated into your work must be explicitly acknowledged and cited in your assignment. You can do so by acknowledging within the text, as a footnote, or a separate table added as an appendix, indicating what Gen AI model you used, the date used, sample prompts given, and how you used the output. In any case, whether you have or have not used any Gen AI in this module, you need to attach this Disclosure to your final Sustainability Diary submission.

Note: Replace “___” with an “X” below to mark/tick against the appropriate options.

- ☐ I acknowledge that I **have not** used any Generative AI and LLM models to carry out any task within the Foundations and Sprint Packs or the final Focused Build.
- ☒ I acknowledge that I **have** used Generative AI and LLM models to carry out the following tasks as a part of this assignment and I provide the details of such use below.

Mark “X” against all the tasks or activities you used Gen AI and LLM models to carry out.

- ☒ Search for and collect information related to the practical sustainability issues
- ☐ Search for academic articles and published papers on the chosen topic/cause/issue/context/etc
- ☒ Summarize and synthesize academic articles and published papers
- ☐ Summarise, synthesize, and connect academic sources with practical information to generate ideas of how academic lenses enable understanding practical issues
- ☐ Generate ideas for Rights Trace Map, Systems Map, Measures, and/or Interventions
- ☐ Design, implement, evolve, and/or populate the Knowledge Expansion Log
- ☒ Copyedit the assignment, meaning checking and correcting spelling, grammar, tenses, tone/voice, sentence construction, writing style, etc.

X Generate partial or complete pieces of written text, images, videos, graphics, etc. that are used in the assignment in their original form as generated by Gen AI or modified by me

In the case of use of Gen AI for any purpose in this assignment, it is mandatory that you ONLY use Google Gemini or Microsoft Auto-Pilot accessed through DCU student ID to ensure no information you share with Gen AI is used to train the models and that your and DCU information stays secure. In case of use of Gen AI for any purpose, please indicate whether this rule has been followed or not by ticking the below disclosure.

X I understand that only Google Gemini or Microsoft Auto-Pilot accessed through DCU student ID is allowed to be used for this assignment and I assure that this rule has been followed.

While the students have flexibility to use Gen AI in this module, the eventual responsibility of the accuracy, clarity, logic, and transparency of the assignment rests with the student. It is mandatory to tick the below disclosure to submit the assignment irrespective of whether you have used Gen AI or not.

X I understand that it is solely my responsibility to ensure the assignment, in parts and in its whole, is accurate, clear, transparent, and academically ethical despite the use of Gen AI, or not, in any parts of it. In case of the use of Gen AI, I acknowledge that I have checked the accuracy of the assignment including, but not limited to, the references to the sources used in the assignment, the transparency of the use of Gen AI in this disclosure, the guarantee that no confidential information about me, DCU, or my sources of primary data has been shared with any Gen AI model, and that any undisclosed use of Gen AI in parts that have not been acknowledged in this disclosure will be penalized.

Student name: Martinas Jucys Brady

Dated: 10/04/2026